The limited initial success of the coasting trade could barely resolve the company's many difficulties. SSNCo continued to be plagued by troubles, working capital being only one of them. Even as it raised small sums of money to meet recurring expenses, costs continued to overrun revenue. On one occasion, the company had to run around collecting freight money to buy ten tons of coal to keep the steamer's boilers going.[184] The *Lawoe* earned Rs 5,000 in twenty days on its Madras trips; but it cost Rs 500 per day adding up to a loss of Rs 5,000 on running expenses alone. Similarly, the Colombo trip was also losing Rs 5,000 per month.[185]

The company also owed a large sum to its Colombo Agent who was also paying for the coal.[186] In this context, he complained to VOC though he was in prison:

> The Co[mpan]y owes Colombo: To me as Agent for money advanced and comn [commission] Rs. 19,267-79; by drafts accepted, for monies due to me, Rs. 20,164-02, other than the first item; Bills outstanding to local creditors Rs. 10,629/93; total Rs 50,061/74 up to 31st August.[187]

Money alone was not the sticking point. 'Office work rather unsatisfactory and they do not act promptly', Thumbayya complained about SSNCo's management.[188] Other issues were set out in the following terms:

> I regret to say that the relations existing between the Sec[retar]y and myself is far from satisfactory. He persists in delaying remittances to me and puts me to considerable inconvenience and loss by way of interest. Besides, the business here is hardly a profitable one to me as I am personally responsible for the upkeep of the office and staff here, and you know what the Colombo expenses are quite well.
>
> You will remember that I undertook the Agency on the distinct understanding that the Commission of the Boat Co. and the Stevedore are to be allowed me, this being a concession generally allowed steamer agencies. Now, after a lapse of one year, the Secy insists on its going to the Coy's credit. As it is, I lose heavily, but my loss would be considerably more if these two items are now disputed. I shall be quite satisfied if I can keep things going and leave just a small margin for myself. Please therefore confirm the understanding that we came to re the above-named commissions in your reply to this, so that I may speak to the Secy and submit your letter to the Directors.
>
> Re terms of agreement, remittances are not made according to agreement, and I am put to great inconvenience. A Bank a/c has not yet been opened by them.